LIGHTER vs PACIFICA

Executive Brief

November 30, 2025 | Research Only | Not Investment Advice

1. TLDR

- **Lighter** is the stronger all-round perp venue: ≈$1.23B TVL, ≈$298B 30d perp volume, ≈$1.7B OI on an Ethereum-settled zk rollup with forced exits and an LLP insurance fund. **Final score: 76/100.**
- **Pacifica** is the high-speed Solana local max: >$1B daily notional, ≈$40M TVL, ≈$50–60M OI, hybrid off-chain engine + on-chain Solana settlement, 50x leverage, CEX-like UX. **Final score: 67/100.**
- **Both are pre-token, points-driven and centralized today.** Lighter has big VC backing, zero retail fees and a structured points program but no LIGHT token design yet. Pacifica is self-funded with no VC, Pacifica Points, and a speculative future PACIFICA token with contradictory emission numbers.
- **Governance and upgrade risk are material on both.** Lighter is a Stage 0 rollup with instant-upgrade powers and partially unverified oracle feeds; Pacifica is team-controlled with upgradeable contracts and undisclosed Squads multisig signers.

INSTITUTIONAL STANCE: Lighter looks like a candidate future "core perp infra" position once tokenomics and governance decentralize. Pacifica sits in a watchlist / high-beta Solana perps bucket until contract transparency, governance and post-incentive stickiness improve.

2. SNAPSHOT: LIGHTER vs PACIFICA

Aspect	Lighter (Ethereum)	Pacifica (Solana)
Architecture	Ethereum L1 settlement, zk rollup, centralized sequencer, forced exits	Solana L1 programs, trusted off-chain matching, future Substrate L1 planned
TVL / OI	≈$1.23B TVL, ≈$1.7B OI	≈$40M TVL, ≈$50–60M OI
Volume	≈$298B 30d perps	>$1B daily (~54% Solana share)
Fees	Zero retail; revenue from funding, liquidations, institutional/API	≈0.015% maker, ≈0.04% taker + fee promos and points
Leverage	Multi-tier margin, LLP-backed "gentler" liquidations	Up to 50x, cross/isolated margin, hybrid CEX/DEX risk engine
Oracles	Stork (crypto), Chainlink (RWA); signatures not fully verified on-chain	Likely Pyth/Switchboard; not fully specified
Token Status	No token; Points Season 2 (250k/week); LIGHT design unknown	No token; Pacifica Points; PACIFICA terms contradictory
Funding	≈$90M raised at $1.5B valuation (Founders Fund, Haun, Ribbit, etc.)	Self-funded, no VC; team-concentrated control
Governance	Stage 0 rollup, upgradeable, 3/5 security council, no exit window	Team-controlled, Squads multisig, undisclosed signers, DAO "later"

3. STRENGTHS, WEAKNESSES, USE CASES

LIGHTER

Strengths:
• Scale & depth: Among largest perp DEXs by TVL, OI and volume
• Security: Ethereum settlement, forced exits, LLP insurance
• Economics: Zero retail fees + strong revenue from funding/liquidations

Key Risks:
• Stage 0 governance with instant upgrades
• Oracle feeds not fully verified on-chain
• Unknown token design (LIGHT supply, allocation)

Best-fit Users:
• High-size pro traders and MMs wanting depth + Ethereum settlement
• EVM and RWA-focused traders (BTC/ETH/SOL + FX/commodities)

PACIFICA

Strengths:
• Performance: Sub-10ms matching, 50x leverage, CEX-like UI
• Positioning: Top Solana perp DEX by volume and share
• Self-funded: No VC allocations, cleaner potential distribution

Key Risks:
• Governance opacity: Undisclosed multisig signers
• Token limbo: Contradictory emission numbers, mapping unknown
• Economic fragility: High notional vs thin TVL/OI

Best-fit Users:
• Solana-native, speed-focused traders comfortable with governance risk
• Speculators who like "self-funded, no VC" story

4. SIMPLE PERSONA VERDICTS

Persona	Verdict
High-size pro trader / MM	Use Lighter as primary venue. Pacifica is an optional Solana satellite, not a core risk book at current state.
Points / airdrop farmer	Favor Lighter for expected token size and clearer program; Pacifica as smaller, higher-uncertainty side farm.
Casual degen, chain-agnostic (<$10k)	Lighter by default (zero fees, deep books, Ethereum). Pacifica only if you specifically want Solana + CEX UX.
Solana-native trader	Pacifica is the natural home for now. Lighter remains more relevant to EVM-native and cross-asset traders.

BOTTOM LINE: Lighter is the default institutional and EVM choice – more absolute liquidity, explicit insurance mechanisms, and Ethereum security guarantees. Pacifica is the tactical Solana native choice – CEX-like performance and ecosystem integration, but thinner capital base and governance opacity limit institutional conviction. Both remain in "research and watchlist" territory until token designs, governance structures, and post-incentive traction are clarified.